

‘WE HAVE A STRONG PRODUCT PLAN FOR INDIA’

It has been quite a journey for Hisashi Takeuchi, from a clerk in Suzuki to the MD & CEO of the company’s biggest operation—India. Excerpts from an interview where he talks about the Maruti Suzuki strategy

BY **PRERNA LIDHOO**

PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

HISASHI TAKEUCHI, the new Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Maruti Suzuki India (MSI), takes charge at a difficult time. Amidst global challenges like supply-side constraints and domestic hiccups arising from MSI’s slipping market share in the past few years, the 58-year-old Takeuchi has his task cut out. The Suzuki Motor Corporation (SMC) veteran will have big shoes to fill: predecessor Kenichi Ayukawa was at the helm for nine years and ushered Maruti’s entry into the premium car segment with the NEXA retail channel. Ayukawa will continue as a Whole-time Director designated as Executive Vice Chairman till September 30 to help with the transition. Takeuchi says his experience in varied markets, including Japan, Australia and Hungary, has prepared him well to handle India, which is SMC’s single-largest market. Edited excerpts:



What’s your vision for India’s automotive industry now that you’re in charge of MSI?

I’m excited to be in the driver’s seat of the biggest Indian automotive company. Since I joined the Suzuki group, I first worked as just a clerk in the European market, and I was... still in my 20s. My goal at that time was to get more experience and more expertise in the automotive industry. Then I got my first overseas assignment in Australia. That was a big change for me, and I learnt a lot about



SILVER LINING Maruti Suzuki MD & CEO Hisashi Takeuchi says he has an opportunity to gradually improve market share in India